

Vertigo!!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 687 April 2006 PO BOX 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

Club nights are at Turnbull House, on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher public bar at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea and coffee afterwards.



April 3rd Section Night 8:00 pm

In the footsteps of Charles Howard-Bury... In 1921 Col Charles Howard-Bury, on the first reconnaissance of Everest, traveled up the Kama or "Hidden" Valley to the Kangshung Face. They were the first Europeans to look down into the Rongbuk and climbed to the North Col at 6700m.

Section member Nicky McIndoe and her partner, Andrei Van Dusschoten traveled from Tingiri in Tibet to the Kangshung Face, following the same route as Howard -Bury, with no support.

After a brief AGM, Nicky will talk about her experiences organising and traveling to a very remote and inhospitable area of Tibet.



Mike Peat on the summit of The Minarets



Annual General Meeting

The Annual General meeting of the Wellington Section of the NZAC will be held at 8pm on Monday April 3rd 2005 at Turnbull House. The minutes of the 2005 AGM are available on the section website at http://www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz/mainpages/agm_2005.doc.

Nominations are now open for the following positions: Chairperson, Vice Chairperson, Secretary, Treasurer, General Committee Members, National Representative (2 positions). Nominations can be made via email to secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz or on the night.

A short message from Garth, current Vice Chairperson:

“The committee is in need of new volunteers who are after fun, excitement, travel and adventure for a generous salary and plentiful annual leave entitlement. Even if that doesn't appeal we still need you! The section cannot run without the generous work done by its volunteers and numbers have slipped so low at the moment that we can hold committee meetings in a phone box!”



Section trips news

Please send all your fantastic trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories.



Tearing Up the Tasman

Yibai He, Tom Wilson and the writer (Mike Peat) headed south for a week of mountaineering in the 3rd week of November. We winged our way south to Christchurch on the back of a promising forecast, and pointed our rental car west to Fox Glacier. Gearing up in the car park at HEL Porter light rain began to fall, we headed down to the helipad feeling less optimistic about our chances of getting in. Our optimism took a further dive when we met our pilot, a grumpy character with deep furrows in his forehead - clearly the result of a 40 year frown. We dubbed him ‘handle bar man’ due to the moustache that grew down almost to his jaw line. Despite the rain and late hour handlebar man decided to give it a shot, and after a fifteen minute flight he slipped us above the cloud to Pioneer Hut and landed us just after the nightly radio sched.

Due to our late arrival the previous night we decided to have an easy first day and found ourselves enjoying the sunshine on the TV slabs of Mt Alack. Then it was back to the hut, an early dinner, and into bed before our first alpine start the following morning. We settled on the north shoulder route on Mt Tasman, which involves gaining the divide at Marcel Col and traversing over Mt Lendenfeld and Engineer Col. We made good time but I had been feeling off colour so on the summit of Lendenfeld at 3am I made the decision to turn back and wait at Marcel Col to give Tom and Yibai the best chance of success. After a couple of hours sleep on the Col I was feeling much better decided to climb Mt Haast. From the summit I could see Tom and Yibai on the north shoulder still on their way up. I was now feeling 100% and decided to catch the boys up, so I quickly descended Haast and reclimbed Lendenfeld in time to meet 2 Franz Glacier Guides on the summit returning from their successful climb of Tasman. They had climbed unroped saying conditions had been good on the ascent, but that it had gotten dangerously soft due to the warm conditions during their descent. In light of this new information I decided to abandon my

own attempt and settled in to wait for Tom and Yibai to return. The weather was excellent and I was able to pass the time chatting to various parties that arrived atop Lendenfeld and watching the lads inching up and then back down their mountain. Good effort guys, for Yibai the day had seen him climb his first 3000m peaks.

The next day was also a cracker but following the big effort of the previous day we had a relaxing morning before heading over to Centennial Hut which is about two and a half hours trudge in the heat and soft afternoon snow. Our objective was the Minarets via the standard route from near Graham Saddle. Yet another fine windless morning greeted us the following morning for our 4am start, we headed off with a reasonable freeze, but the warm west wind soon brought in a heavy fog which combined with the lack of any moonlight obscured the route ahead. As it was almost dawn we decided to sit and wait for better visibility. We didn't have to wait long before it lightened and cleared enough to pick a route through the crevasses and within an hour we were up on the broad saddle between de La Beche and the Minarets. According to Murphy the further summit would be the higher, and a check of the map confirmed that he was right. The schrund didn't give us any trouble and not long later we were on top. Great views west to the northern snowfields of the Franz Josef Glacier and to the rugged bush clad valleys beyond, and to the east the entire length of the Tasman Glacier could be seen. The slopes below de La Beche are exposed to rockfall and we were anxious to get back down before the sun hit the route. One abseil was required over a tricky schrund on the descent and a couple of hours later we were back at the hut. After a siesta lasting a couple of hours we packed up and headed back to Pioneer. Tom and Yibai did a sterling job breaking trail in the oppressive heat while I enjoyed a free ride in the middle of the rope.

We had a flight out booked with a couple of Aussies for lunchtime the next day, Tom and I decided to have a look at Mt Alack while Yibai opted for more sleep. We had 5 hours to get up and back which should have been enough except that the route we tried first (pioneer ridge) consisted essentially of loosely stacked shards of rock. We decided we were too old to die young so descended and headed over to the ridge leading up behind the TV slabs which looked much better. By now time had got on and with our flight not far off we decided to turn back, imagine our disappointment later then when despite the perfect weather up top the choppers didn't fly at all due to valley cloud.

The next day was a similar forecast so we elected to head down early to Chancellor Hut and fly or walk from there. As dawn arrives in the lowlands the birds sing but in the highlands its Yibai's camera that sings. And today was no exception, there we were below Chancellor Dome as the first rays of sunlight graced the peaks, out came the camera, there was no escape as he had us hog tied by the rope between us. Panoramas, close-ups, portraits, group shots, stand here, stand there, do this, that, I've still got 400 shots on this film he exclaimed excitedly. By combined mental power we were unable to accelerate the earth's rotation but Yibai's shutter finger soon tired and we resumed our march. It turned out to be a good move heading down as the ubiquitous valley cloud prevented choppers getting to the neve, but Chancellor was just below the cloud ceiling so we got out ok.

Thanks for a memorable trip guys.

Mike Peat



Nank on a Mission

Hopeless. On the weekend prior to Christmas Clinton Wadsworth, Wanda Stratford, Martin Kennedy and John Nankervis traversed Hopeless from a camp (actually a wet bivvy rock) in Cupola Stream. Went up the south ridge in dryish conditions and descended in the rain down the Couloir.

Rees. Over New Year weekend John Cocks, Paul Denys, Graeme Morrison and John Nankervis climbed Clarke and the Northern Osonzac Twin from a camp above Clarke Slip in the Rees

valley. Again rain intervened on top and a very windy and wet night followed before they retreated to the pleasures of the Alpine Club camp down valley.

Selkirks. In February an inter-section team skied in Canada. First week was spent at ski hills in southern BC and then a week ski touring from a lodge in the Durrand Glacier area, north of Rogers Pass in the Selkirks. It snowed continuously during that period, so there was not much time spent in the high alpine - instead THE TREES ("Ski good or eat wood"). The team: Dara and Nick Shearer (North Otago), Pete Platts (Canty), John Wild, Tim Stern and John Nankervis (Welly).

Tibet. In September/October last year a team with a considerable average age - Stu Gray, John Cocks, Dave Ellis, Geoff Spearpoint, Nick Shearer and John Nankervis - climbed in Southern Tibet. They flew into Lhasa from Chengdu, travelled to the road end at Kharta village and then split their time between two areas. From a base camp in the Kharta valley on the eastern side of Everest they climbed Karma Changri and 3 other peaks, all between 6,000 and 6,500 metres. The latter three were probably either first ascents or new routes. Some of the team returned to Kharta village the long way by the Karpo La (6,000m) and the beautiful Kangshung valley. The shorter part of the trip was in the remote Nyonno Ri range on the opposite (eastern) side of the Phungchu (Arun river). There they completed a beautiful trekking circuit, meeting the Arun again in the forest, just north of where it flows into Nepal. On the way they climbed a virgin peak of 5,750 metres which afforded a magnificent view of much higher parts of the massif. The weather was mainly good in both areas but there were occasional light snowfalls.

John Nankervis



Fine Weather 5 Cross Ball Pass

Given the garbage weather that we were experiencing in the New Year at Takaka and a bad forecast we called off the plans to head in to Pioneer and decided the weather was in the east so it was into the east that we headed. Mt Cook was howling on our arrival but there was a window of opportunity, two days when we might be able to get something done, then hell was going to rain down on the area. With no rivers to cross and some good bail out options we made the call to do Ball Pass.

Monday morning saw us packing for a quick trip so all the unessentials and spare anythings were discarded. Thanks to Angie and the trusty Subaru Outback we were able to put 7 or 8 km of the Ball Pass road behind us and four o'clock saw us leaving Ball Shelter for a bivouac up on the ridge. The weather was superb with no wind and fantastic views of the Tasman and Ball Glaciers, Mt Cook and all the other peaks on that side. This was the second trip up the Ball Ridge for me and it was surprising to see how little snow was around. The basins below Caroline Hut, where on a previous trip we had donned crampons, were empty. Arriving at the Hut at 8:30pm and with no other occupants, we made the call to bivouac there. At least we would have an environmentally friendly toilet handy! A quick feed whilst watching a truly spectacular sun set and then it was into the bags for a short sleep.



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At four in the morning and we were up for another feed and on our way by 5:30. The scramble up to the ridge was the typical scree and then some nice rock along the ridge took us to the Ball Glacier neve. The sun rose on another stunning day and arriving at the Pass at 7:00am the views opened up onto the Hooker Glacier, Mt Sefton, Footstool and over to the Annette Plateau. Descending into the Hooker we knew that the route finding could be a bit tricky and sure enough we ended up bluffed but a short ascent to the ledges, a quick traverse and we were on our way down to the Playing Fields and an early lunch at

10:30am. Looking back up to where we had descended the route was obvious, which is why DOC suggests that the Pass is down in the opposite direction to ours.

After a leisurely 1 1/2 hour stop in hot sun watched by Kea, it was time to get cracking and so it was into the gut that drops to the Hooker moraine. The route is straight forward but the 600m descent down boulders and scree sure takes its toll on the knees. Still much better to travel down this stuff than go up. A short stop at the bottom to fill up with water and it was off on the 2 1/2 hour walk out down the moraine. We were at White Horse Hill by 4:00pm and off to Unwin to enjoy a well earned beer.

The next day it bucketed down at Unwin.

We were Garth London, Craig Robinson, Cat Robinson, Mike Courtney, Rachael Schmidt and supported by Angie London.



Section General News



The Banff Film Festival is back!

The NZ Alpine Club presents the worlds premier film festival for outdoor sports.

The Banff Mountain Film Festival is back for another great year and it is bigger and better than ever. Banff 2006 now spans two nights starting with Sunday April 30th and then Tuesday May 2nd.

The format will be the same as always, starting at 6:30 pm at the Paramount theatre, with 150 minutes of film each night, spot prizes and an MC to present each of the movies.

Each Session will have its own distinct program, so if you want to see all the great movies you will have to go to both. The individual programs won't be published, so it will be pot luck if there is a particular film you are interested in.

Some highlights from this year's festival are:

Sur le file des 4000 (Grand Prize Winner)

On March 1, 2004, Patrick Bérhault and Philippe Magnin set out to climb all 82 summits above 4000 metres in the Alps. Well-known for their solid experience and purist approach to climbing, they brave changing weather and strong emotions as they proceed on their long journey. On April 28, they are making their way along Nadelgrat, an interminable ridge leading up to their 67th summit, when destiny steps in.

Proszacur (Best film on Mountain Sports)

79 year-old Janusz Orlowski is full of energy and zeal. There is nothing special about this — except that he flies. He is a paraglider. The paraglider's environment is always changing, but young people dominate the sport. The frail, old man doesn't really "fit" into this environment, but the youngsters have accepted him. Flying is Janusz's passion and requires health, agility, and stamina. Consequently, he must overcome all the limitations that come with age. He gets help from his younger friends and sometimes falters, but he never gives up. Janusz says he will always fly.

Magic Mountain (Peoples Choice Award)

This film recounts the offbeat story of educator Cynthia Hunt, the founder of HEALTH (Health, Environment and Literacy in the Himalayas) in Ladakh, northwest India. Her often theatrical efforts to empower illiterate women propel viewers on a rare and exhilarating journey as she hikes over 5000-metre (16,000-foot) passes and through a frozen river gorge deeper than the Grand Canyon.

Parralelojams (Best film on Climbing)

An award-winning look at the challenges and characters of modern desert crack climbing, featuring hilarious commentary by Timmy O'Neill. Includes Didier Berthod's first ascent of "From Switzerland, With Love" (probably the hardest crack in the desert at 5.13+R), Eric Decaria's inspiring repeat of the hairball arête "Air Swedin" (5.13R), Timmy O'Neill's traverse of the Bridger-Jacks highline (slack lining) and much, much more.

Harvest Moon

A Swiss expedition climbs a technically challenging new route on Thalay Sagar (22,650 feet, 6903 metres) in the Garwhal Himalaya of northern India. Stephan Siegrist, Denis Burdet, Thomas Senf, and Ralph Weber tackle the northwest ridge, on the right side of the mountain's 4600-foot (1400-metre) north face. Interviews with noted climbers give background and perspective on the mountain's challenges.

Tickets (\$15) will be available from Bivouac, Mountain Designs, and Mainly Tramping from the beginning of April. They will also be available at the section night at Turnbull House on Monday 3 April from 8:00pm. Should you need to purchase tickets "remotely" send an email to MD@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz to arrange and EFT payment and ticket allocation.

The full festival details are available on the club website at www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz/banff



AT THE BAY

The climbing at Whanganui Bay is as good as it ever was, and the weather there is nearly always great – but the campsite needs some work. It's getting overgrown, and could do with trees, for shelter as well as landscaping. Mere says they would like natives, and Wellington Section could maybe put together a layout and a work program. If all of us donated one tree, there would be more than enough!

The track from the carpark to the campsite is very broken up and goes underwater after rain, especially now the lake level is so high. It needs to be made into a raised footpath. Cars shouldn't use it: if you're old, infirm or carrying babies, the road that goes off to the right before the carpark is OK but cars will be scratched unless someone cuts back the blackberry. And of course this is only for a quick turnaround to drop off or pick up gear. The carpark itself also needs some clearing, since it's become quite small.

So we need some work parties – volunteers should contact Blair Hiscoke (blairh@boffamiskell.co.nz) or James Wright (james.wright@xtra.co.nz) The locals may be able to help with the clearing – ask Mere about this and talk to her about what you are planning to do. Mere also says that they will soon need help with the tuku tuku weaving on the marae, something that only the women can do.

Some temporary signs have gone up, telling climbers not to bring their cars (or dogs) down to the campgrounds. These rules seemed to have been forgotten, and Mere would be grateful if we could all help to remind people about them. These signs will be replaced soon with smart new NZAC ones.

As a trade, Wellington Section can now provide a hammer drill and reasonably priced bolts for members who want to put up new climbs, and there will shortly be a North Island bolting course – contact Kristen Foley (kristen.foley@weltec.ac.nz) for details.



Thankyou from The Persson Family

In the New Year a Thankyou Card was received from Kaj and Maria Persson, Kris Persson's family. Kris and his partner Vanessa Johnson were tragically killed in Bolivia last August while on a mountaineering adventure there.

Members of the section sent condolence books to both families. They expressed their thanks for the kind words that Kris' climbing friends offered in their book.

Donations have been received from members and the families and the Section Committee is looking at appropriate ways to use these.

Silent Auction

Kris's family has also donated some of Kris's belongings to the section. These items are for sale via a silent auction. Prospective buyers are invited to submit their bids for any item via email to auction@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz with 'NZAC Auction' in the subject line. The auction will close at midnight on Wednesday 26 April 2006 and the goods will be available to be picked up at the May Section night (Monday 1 May). Photos of the items are available on the website (www.nzalpine.wellington.net.nz).

- Item 1: 3 x new snow stakes
- Item 2: 1m steel cable (approx 2mm thick)
- Item 3: 1 x small snow shovel
- Item 4: 1 x mitts (pile inner rubberized outer)
- Item 5: A set of NZTrig maps covering mountain areas
- Item 6: 55m 8.6mm Beal rope (dry type and looks new)
- Item 7: Approx 10m 8.6mm rope (used)
- Item 8: 1 pr rock shoes (Rock Pillars), approx size UK 11 or Eur 46
- Item 9: 1 x chalk bag
- Item 10: 1 x ice axe (Mountain Tech - much used)
- Item 11: 1 x stainless steel billy
- Item 12: 1 x open tin leather waterproofing
- Item 13: 1 x day pack (Hash House Harriers)
- Item 14: 1 x plastic drinking cup
- Item 15: 1 x belay device
- Item 16: 1 x snow goggles
- Item 17: 1 x Arthurs Pass Guide
- Item 18: 1 x Mt Cook Guide
- Item 19: 1 x pack liner (unopened)
- Item 20: 1 x "NZ" cap
- Item 21: 1 packet of odds and ends incl small bottles of rum, Jim Beam, Vodka etc, toothpaste,
- Item 22: candles, shampoo, ear plugs etc. - all opened and partially used.
- Item 23: 1 pr of brand new leather Sketcher shoes, approx size UK 11 or Eur 46
- Item 24: 3 x computer network cables
- Item 25: 2 x computer speakers
- Item 26: 1 sock and glove



Bouldering Online

The BMC is delighted to announce that The North Face UIAA-ICC Bouldering World Cup from Birmingham (17-19 March) will be web cast. Please go to www.thebmc.co.uk/climb06 for further details.



A BIG thanks...

... to those who contributed to the March short talks.

Interesting talks on subjects as diverse as Ball Pass, Mt French and Fox Glacier climbing, Footstool / Du Faur traverse, Tour de Mt Blanc and Judy Reid giving some insight into the proposed section trip to China were followed by a very professionally produced video of Pete De Joux's year in Antarctica.

Garth London

For Sale



Touring ski's and ski mountaineering boots for sale.

- Silvretta 300 touring skis 190cm with silvretta 404 touring bindings
- Koflach ski mountaineering boots-size 41 good condition

Used for 2 seasons in the '90s - good condition. \$500 the lot.

Contact Jay Davison 2336510 or stokesnz@paradise.net.nz

For Sale



I have some gear for urgent sale (heading overseas)

- Technical ice hammer and axe set - DMM 55cm - excellent condition - \$400 for set
- Scarpa Vegas (used but fine) size 44 - \$100
- Charlet Moser Crampons (used but good condition) \$100
- 6 Wild Country cams - med/large sizes - brand new - \$60 each (bargain!)

Would prefer to sell as one lot - and open to offers – cheap! Paul Pringle, 021 774 645, (04) 474 9556

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Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the section, so if anyone has an idea about a trip, no matter how vague, come and chat to Merewyn Ellis (trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz). Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email us, or approach us at the monthly meeting, and we can help you get going.

China Trip

The idea of a climbing trip to China in October/November this year is taking shape. Pat Deavoll, who told us about her first ascent of a mountain in Western China at our last section night, has made some very useful recommendations about climbing objectives. For those not interested in bagging a peak, there will also be rock-climbing and trekking options. Some section members have said they're interested.

An email group has also been set up. To subscribe send an email to china-subscribe@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz. To post messages, email china@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz. The group is restricted to subscribers to prevent spam.

Aconcagua expedition

The highest mountain in the Southern Hemisphere and outside Asia is the perfect choice to take your high altitude trekking to the next level. I'm organizing an Aconcagua expedition between 11/2006 and 02/2007 or 11/2007 and 02/2008 and I'm looking for people to join the core group to work out the details during the next few months. Once the exact budget, date, route and timetable have been set the expedition will be open for any club members to join at a later phase.

Aconcagua does not necessarily require technical climbing skills but experience in high altitude trekking and fitness is required. For those who aim on taking eight-thousanders later Aconcagua is extremely good practise. I am also considering combining an acclimatisation trip to the Cotopaxi (and possibly the other volcanos there) in Ecuador just before the expedition.

Please contact Juho Sarkila through e-mail at jsarkila@gmail.com for more information and visit www.aconcagua.com for general information about the mountain.

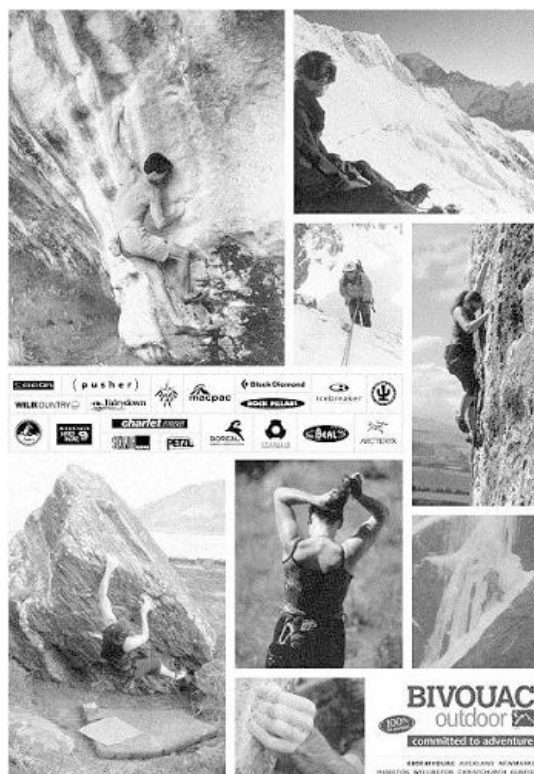


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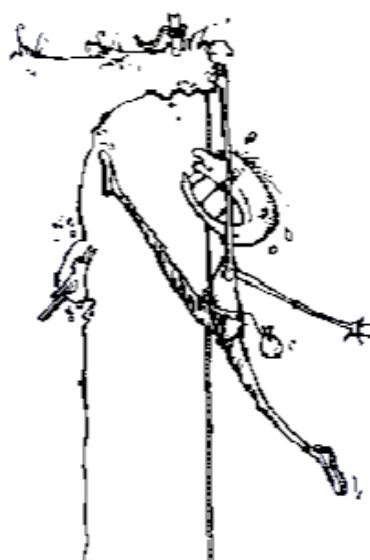




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